Baptized into Christ

Matthew 28:18-20; Romans 6:3-4 (KJV)

Scripture

Matthew 28:18-20

18 And Jesus came and spake unto them, saying, All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth.

19 Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: 20 Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Romans 6:3-4

3 Know ye not, that so many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his death? 4 Therefore we are buried with him by baptism into death: that like as Christ was raised up from the dead by the glory of the Father, even so we also should walk in newness of life.

Outline

1. Commanded by Christ for his disciples

Baptize them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy _____.

Christians baptize because _____ commanded it.

Read: Matthew 28:18-20; Acts 2:41; Acts 8:12

2. Baptized into Christ's death and resurrection

So many of us as were baptized into Jesus Christ were baptized into his _____.

Baptism speaks of our _____ with Christ.

Read: Romans 6:3-4; Galatians 3:27; Colossians 2:12

3. Called to walk in newness of life

We also should walk in _____ of life.

The baptized are called to live as people who belong to the risen _____.

Read: Romans 6:4-11; 2 Corinthians 5:17; Colossians 3:1-3

Where Christians differ

Christians agree that Jesus commanded baptism, that it is done with water in the name of the Father, Son and Holy Spirit, that it is linked with repentance, faith, forgiveness and union with Christ, and that true baptism is not repeated. They differ on three questions: who should be baptized (believers only, or also the children of believers), how (immersion, or also pouring and sprinkling), and what baptism does (a means through which God gives grace, a sign and seal of his covenant, or an act of obedience that testifies to grace already received). Here are the main views of the five traditions, each described as its own teachers describe it. Sincere, Bible-believing Christians hold each of them.

Baptist. Baptists teach "believer's baptism": baptism is for those who have personally repented and put their faith in Christ, and it is done by immersing the whole body in water, picturing death, burial and resurrection with Christ. Baptism is an ordinance of obedience and a public confession of faith; it does not itself save or convey grace, but follows salvation. Because infants cannot yet believe, they are not baptized; many Baptist churches hold a service of dedication instead, and a person baptized as an infant is baptized as a believer.

Methodist and Wesleyan. Methodists and Wesleyans treat baptism as a sacrament: an outward sign of an inward grace and a means by which God works. It marks entry into the church and God's covenant, and it is given both to adults who come to faith and to the infants of Christian families. Pouring or sprinkling is usual, though immersion is also accepted. John Wesley linked baptism with the new birth, but taught that every baptized person must still personally turn to Christ and be born of the Spirit; baptized children are later confirmed in their own profession of faith.

Presbyterian and Reformed. Presbyterian and Reformed churches teach that baptism is a sacrament, a sign and seal of God's covenant of grace, which in the New Testament takes the place of circumcision. It is given to those who profess faith and also to the children of believing parents, because God's covenant promise is "unto you, and to your children" (Acts 2:39). Sprinkling or pouring is usual and immersion is valid. The grace signified is not tied to the moment of baptism and is received by faith; baptism does not automatically regenerate, and it is administered only once.

Lutheran. Lutherans teach that baptism is a means of grace: not simply water, but water joined to God's command and promise. Through it God gives forgiveness of sins, rescue from death and the devil, and eternal salvation to all who believe. Faith receives the gift, and God works faith even in infants through his Word, so children are baptized. The Augsburg Confession calls baptism necessary to salvation (while Lutherans do not teach that the unbaptized who believe are lost). Pouring is the usual mode. The baptized person returns daily to baptism by repentance and faith.

Pentecostal and Charismatic. Most Pentecostal churches (for example the Assemblies of God and the Foursquare Church) practise believer's baptism by immersion, much as Baptists do: an act of obedience and public testimony by those who have been born again, not a means of salvation. Infants are dedicated, not baptized. Pentecostals give special emphasis to a second, distinct "baptism in the Holy Spirit" (see the lesson on spiritual gifts). A minority ("Oneness" Pentecostals) baptize in the name of Jesus only; most Pentecostals use the threefold name of Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

Discussion questions

1. What do all Christians agree about baptism, according to today's passages?

2. Each tradition points to particular verses. Why do sincere Christians reading the same Bible reach different conclusions about baptism?

3. How can we hold our own convictions about baptism while showing love to Christians who practise it differently?

4. What does Romans 6 say baptism should mean for the way we live this week?

This week

This week, find out what your own church teaches about baptism and why, and look up the key texts for that view. If you have not been baptized, talk with your pastor. Pray for the unity of Christians who differ on this question.